

C4 Information Distortion

Formerly: Whispering Gallery. Retitled for clarity while retaining the exercise mechanic.

Pillar	Communication	Difficulty	Level 1
Time Required	25-35 minutes	Group Size	5-12
Mode	Team facilitation	Format	In-person preferred (remote adaptation below)
Prerequisites	None	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Ambiguous timeframes, incomplete information, slow/inconsistent communication, frequent rework due to misunderstanding

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

The brain does not store and retrieve information like a computer. Every time a message passes through a person, their brain reconstructs it through their own filters: assumptions, priorities, emotional state, and cognitive biases. This is not carelessness. It is how human memory and communication work at a neurological level.

This exercise makes information distortion visible and tangible. When the team sees the message degrade in real time, the prefrontal cortex engages with the problem as a systems issue rather than a blame issue. This reframing is critical: most teams treat miscommunication as someone's fault rather than a predictable feature of how brains process information.

The Exercise

Phase 1: The Telephone Round (8 minutes)

Use a piece of real work information (a project update, a client requirement, a process change) rather than a random sentence. This makes the distortion immediately relevant.

WHAT TO SAY

"I'm going to give one person a piece of information. They'll pass it to the next person, and so on until it reaches the end. The rule: you can only say it once. No repeating, no clarifying questions. Let's see what happens."

After the final person receives the message, they state it aloud. The original person states the original. Display both side by side.

Phase 2: Distortion Analysis (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Where did the message change? Not who changed it. Where in the chain did meaning shift, and what kind of shift was it? Did details drop out? Did assumptions get added? Did the emotional emphasis change?"

Map the distortion types on the flipchart. Common types: detail loss (numbers, names, dates), assumption insertion (filling gaps with what seemed logical), priority shift (emphasising what mattered to the relay person, not the original sender), emotional colouring (adding urgency or minimising significance).

Phase 3: Real-World Application (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"This wasn't just a game. These same distortion patterns happen every day in our team's communication. Where have you seen them? Where has a message you sent arrived at its destination with different meaning than you intended?"

Collect specific examples. Then the practical question: "What would reduce distortion in our most critical communication? Which of these distortion types is most dangerous for our work?"

Agree on one structural change: written confirmation for key decisions, a standard format for project updates, or a 'read-back' protocol for critical information.

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
Someone feels embarrassed about how much they changed the message	Normalise immediately: "This is not about anyone's memory or skills. This is how brains work. Every single one of us would distort the message, because our brains are not designed to be photocopiers. The question is what systems we put in place to catch the distortion."

Remote/Hybrid Adaptation

Element	Remote Modification
Telephone mechanic	Use private DMs in sequence rather than whispering. Person 1 DMs Person 2, who DMs Person 3, etc. The facilitator monitors the DM chain to track where distortion occurs.
Display	Share the original and final messages on screen side by side for the analysis phase.
Alternative format	For remote teams, a written telephone exercise works well: each person writes a one-paragraph project update, passes it to the next person who rewrites it from memory, and so on.

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
C1: Communication Audit	C1 identifies which channels are unreliable. C4 reveals WHY they're unreliable (distortion patterns).	Run C1 before C4
C13: Asynchronous Communication	Async communication is particularly vulnerable to distortion because there's no immediate clarification opportunity.	Complementary
R1: Micro-Reflection	Post-meeting reflection prompts ("What did I hear? What do I need to confirm?") reduce distortion in daily work.	Complementary